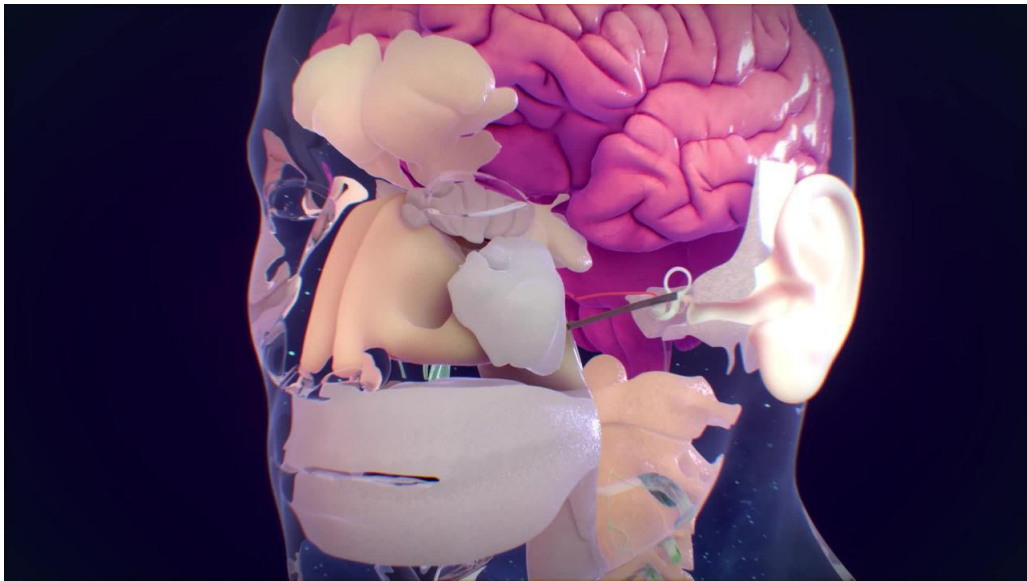






Nasal Congestion and Discharge

(Runny Nose; Rhinorrhea)

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Nasal congestion and discharge (a runny nose) are extremely common problems that commonly occur together but occasionally occur alone.

Causes of Nasal Congestion and Discharge

Common causes

The most common causes of nasal congestion and discharge are

- Viral upper respiratory infections (colds)
- Allergic reactions

Less common causes

Less common causes include

- Sinus infection (sinusitis)
- Foreign object (body) in the nose
- Overuse of decongestant sprays
- Vasomotor rhinitis

Fluid sometimes drains from an infected sinus.

Children sometimes put a foreign object in their nose. If adults do not see them doing this, the first sign may be a foul-smelling nasal discharge due to infection and irritation from the foreign object. Rarely, adults with mental disorders insert foreign objects in their nose.

Evaluation of Nasal Congestion and Discharge

Not all episodes of nasal congestion and discharge require immediate evaluation by a doctor. The following information can help people decide whether a doctor's evaluation is needed and help them know what to expect during the evaluation.

Warning signs

In people with nasal congestion and discharge, certain symptoms and characteristics are cause for concern. They include

- Discharge from only one side of the nose, particularly if it contains pus or blood
- Facial pain, tenderness, or both

When to see a doctor

People should see a doctor right away if either of the following occurs:

- They have warning signs.
- Their caregiver thinks they may have put something in their nose.

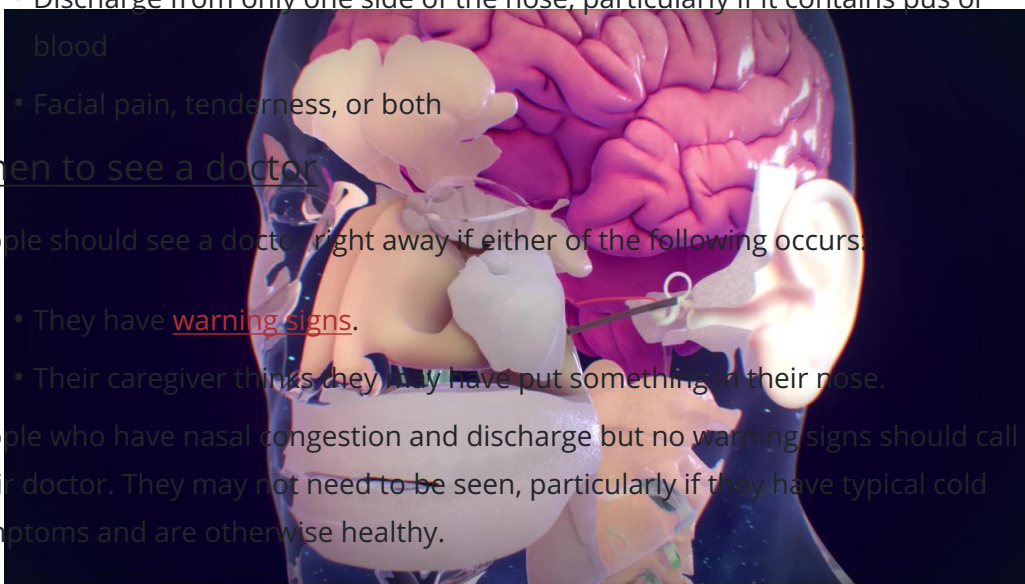
People who have nasal congestion and discharge but no warning signs should call their doctor. They may not need to be seen, particularly if they have typical cold symptoms and are otherwise healthy.

What the doctor does

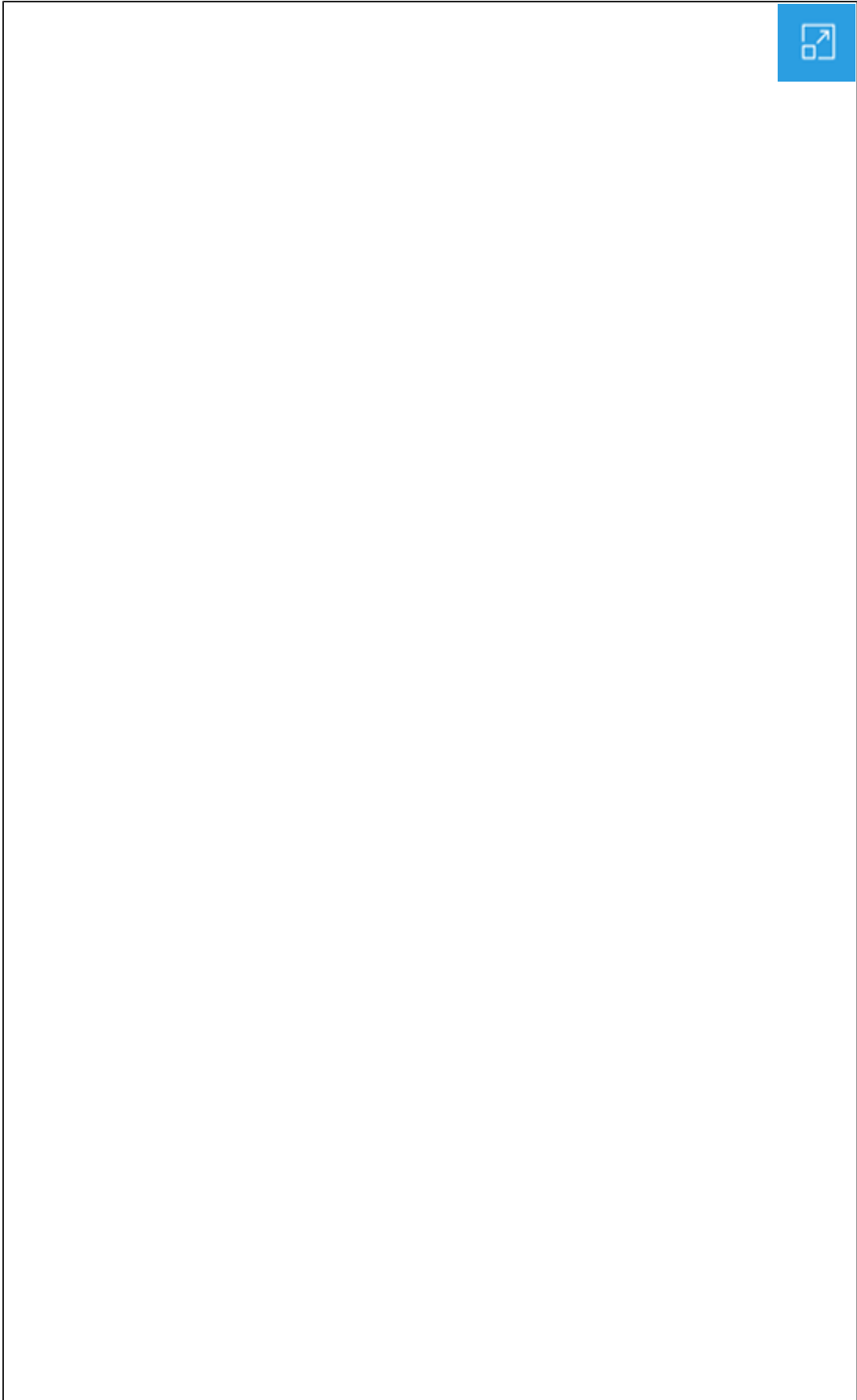
Doctors first ask questions about the person's symptoms and medical history and then do a physical examination. What doctors find during the history and physical examination often suggests a cause of the nasal congestion and discharge and the tests that may need to be done.

During the medical history, doctors ask about the following:

- The nature of the discharge (such as whether it is watery, sticky, pus-filled, or bloody) and whether it is present most or all of the time (chronic) or comes and goes
- Symptoms of possible causes, including fever and face pain (sinusitis); watery, itchy eyes, itchy nose, sneezing (allergies); and sore throat, a general feeling of illness (malaise), fever, and cough (viral upper respiratory infection),



People with vasomotor rhinitis have a recurrent watery nasal discharge that occurs usually in response to ambient changes in temperature, pressure, and humidity.



Some Causes and Features of Nasal Congestion and Discharge

Cause	Common Features*
Acute sinusitis (a sinus infection that just started)	A mucus- and pus-filled discharge, often from only one side of the nose Sometimes a foul or metallic taste in the mouth, facial pain or headache, and redness or tenderness over the cheeks or above the eyebrows No itching and no eye or throat irritation
Allergies	A watery discharge, sneezing, and watery, itchy eyes Pale, soft, swollen membranes lining the nose (nasal mucosa), seen during the examination Symptoms that often occur during certain seasons or after exposure to possible triggers
Atrophic rhinitis	Chronic rhinitis in which the mucous membrane thins (atrophies) and hardens, causing the nasal passages to widen (dilate) and dry out Crusts inside the nose and an offensive odor
Decongestant sprays if overused	Congestion that returns when the decongestant wears off (rebound congestion) Pale, extremely swollen nasal mucosa No discharge



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